

3 Scientific Psychology

Kishin - Psych has never had 1 dominant
theory (so have a bunch of diff ones).
(big neuroscience may beat everything out eventually)

10 The Nineteenth Century: The Authority of Science

Exam question
(based claim, how
would you respond)

A Note on the Debt to the Nineteenth Century

Contemporary psychology, in its broadest features, remains a nineteenth-century enterprise. This is by no means to say that modern psychology is “old-fashioned” or behind the times. Still, it must be noted that the problems that consume the energy of the contemporary psychologist were either set forth explicitly in the nineteenth century or were introduced by those whose educational and cultural backgrounds were provided by the unique perspective of the nineteenth century. Of those who can lay claim to a significant contribution to the manner in which the contemporary psychologist advances the discipline, only B. F. Skinner (1904–1989) was born in this century. All the rest—Lashley, Piaget, Freud, Adler, Hull, Pavlov, Tolman, Köhler, Watson, Dewey, and James—are products of the century now under consideration. This fact is not a mere fact, but a suggestive and a revealing one. Modern psychology is not “modern” in the sense that modern physics and modern biology are. Recent discoveries of the molecular biology of the gene have transformed genetics into a discipline that Mendel scarcely would recognize, and the general theory of relativity has required the contemporary physicist to view the Newtonian universe through Einsteinian lenses.

In psychology, the situation is really quite different. The full range of its theoretical problems—from the study of personality and child development to inquiries into the neurophysiological basis of emotion or language to attempts to comprehend the determinants of social and national movements—can be traced directly to the thoughts and experiments of the psychologists and “natural philosophers” of the nineteenth century. Physicists no longer test the validity of Ohm’s law or seek to discover whether, in fact, Maxwell’s displacement current exists. They do not commit their lives to repeating those experiments that confirm the law of the conservation of energy or of angular momentum. Nor do they seek the “aether,” or insist that light must be either particulate